

Super MAGFest Indie Arcade Developer Guide

Last updated: 2026-09-14



Table of Contents

[Welcome!](#)

[What to Expect](#)

[About the Staff](#)

[Harassment Policy](#)

[What you get](#)

[Floor Space](#)

[Power](#)

[WiFi](#)

[Before the Event](#)

[Discord](#)

[Data Collection](#)

[Prepping Your Game](#)

[What to Bring](#)

[Load In](#)

[Badge Pickup](#)

[Ribbons](#)

[During The Event](#)

[Setup, Con't](#)

[Discord](#)

[Problems](#)

[Storage](#)

[Events](#)

[Tournaments](#)

[MAGFest](#)

[After The Event](#)

[Load Out](#)

[Feedback](#)

[Discord](#)

Welcome!

Congratulations on your acceptance into this year's Indie Arcade showcase! This document will serve as a guide for what to expect between now and the end of the event. Due to the nature of what we show, this guide can't be completely exhaustive, and you are encouraged to email indiearcade@magfest.org or reach out on our Discord with any outstanding questions

What to Expect

MAGFest is not like other events that you may have shown your game at. It is a 72-hour party marathon.

Here's a pretty good walkthrough of our space during the 2024 event that should hopefully give you a good idea of what to expect: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uF1XWFxr9P4>

Some important notes:

- The lights are pretty low, keep this in mind for any signage you may have
- There's usually a DJ or chiptune artist playing music, at least at night
- Overwhelmingly, the developers in our space will set their game up on Thursday and walk away for the remainder of the weekend, leaving their game running the entire time. We recognize that some games will need to be attended, and you are welcome to hang out and run your game as you see fit, but we do generally prefer that games be running for the full duration of the event (including overnight)
- There are a surprising amount of attendees still [out and about playing games at 4am](#)
- Alt control games tend to be somewhat fragile, and MAGFest often serves as the ultimate stress test. Attendees are generally respectful, but you should still be prepared for people to engage with your hardware in ways you may not have expected, and anticipate needing to make emergency repairs or replace parts during the event.

About the Staff

The Indie Arcade is comprised entirely of volunteers. Everyone you interact with is donating their time to make sure you have a great experience. There is a central ops booth where there will always be at least two dedicated Indie Arcade staff available to assist you to the best of their ability.

Harassment Policy

MAGFest is dedicated to providing a safe, welcoming, and harassment-free festival experience for everyone. Anyone from any lifestyle is welcome at MAGFest, as long as they do not intentionally do any action that hinders the enjoyment of other attendees. Harassment of any kind, including but not limited to: physical assault, sexual assault, sexual harassment, battery, deliberate intimidation, stalking, harassing photography or recording, or unwelcome physical attentions, will not be tolerated.

If an individual stalks, harasses, or attempts to assault you at a MAGFest event, please report that individual to a member of the event staff as soon as possible, and appropriate action will be taken. If you witness harassment occurring, please encourage the victim to report it to event staff.

You can view the full Code of Conduct at <https://super.magfest.org/codeofconduct/>

What you get

As a developer in the Indie Arcade, you will be provided with:

1. Two comped badges to the event
2. The opportunity to book a hotel room in the Gaylord, at your own expense

Floor Space

You'll also get space to show your game on the expo floor! Due to the varied nature of games we show, this will vary depending on your specific game. We strive to show as many games as possible, and don't have traditional booths that one would see at a trade show, so we will generally allocate you the smallest of the following categories:

1. If you are bringing an arcade cabinet, your cabinet will be placed among other cabinets shown by developers, with enough room for players, but generally fitting into a traditional "arcade" feel. Bartop cabinets are welcome, and will be set up in the same area as traditional arcade cabinets, but laid out on a series of tables.
2. If you are bringing a game that can be set up on a tabletop, you will receive either two 6'x18" tables or one 6'x3' table, depending on availability, allocated in an approximately 6'x6' floor space. These are arranged openly in the space, and there will be no backdrop or tablecloths provided. You will also receive 2 chairs, if needed. You are free to decorate your space as you see fit, so get creative :) (note: no enclosed structures are permitted, so don't put up a gazebo or a tent)
3. If you have a game that sets up on the floor, you will be allocated the same table setup as above, but are largely free to remove the tables during setup. We may request that some tables be left in place to separate your game's space from others' / clearly define attendee spaces vs developer spaces

4. If you have something that takes up a large amount of floor space, needs to be against a wall, or has any other unique requirements, we will discuss how to accommodate your particular game(s)'s needs in advance of the festival

Power

You will be provided with at least 1 standard power outlet for use. Please bring your own powerstrip/extension cords/etc as needed

WiFi

There is very limited Wifi available in the expo halls. If your game requires internet connectivity, we will provide credentials to you, although we cannot guarantee the quality of service. If you have something akin to online leaderboards, you should assume you will not have wifi.

Before the Event

Discord

We share a Discord server with MIVS (the MAGFest Indie Videogame Showcase— The department that handles “traditional” indie games) as well as Indie Retro. You are required to join this Discord server, and it will serve as the primary location for instructions before, during, and immediately after the event.

Data Collection

We will need to collect data from you for different purposes, including managing our event layout, boosting you on social media, properly crediting you in the event's guidebook, etc. Most of this information will be collected via your developer checklist, though some of it may come via other sources (e.g. Google Forms)

Some things we'll need from you:

- **BADGE INFORMATION** - Your team will receive two comped badges. We will need a First Name, Last Name, and email address to create each of these badges.
- **HOTEL INFORMATION** - We need a primary contact email address to send your hotel booking information to
- **SETUP INFORMATION** - We asked this during the application process, but we need detailed information about what your needs in the expo hall are. This includes, but is not limited to, floor space, light requirements, sound requirements, special needs
- **SOCIAL MEDIA** - We need to know what accounts to promote and where to promote them!

- MERCH - If you want MAGFest Indies to sell merch on your behalf at our Indie Island merch booth, you'll need to tell us what merch you're bringing
- TOURNAMENTS - If you want to run a tournament for your game, we need some information to make that happen
- GUIDEBOOK - MAGFest uses Guidebook, a third party app, to deliver the schedule and attractions to attendees. We will need a description of your game, a 240x240 thumbnail image, and a 640x240 header image
- AT-EVENT BRANDING - We try to put up QR codes around every game so attendees can get more information on the games on display. We need a link to point the QR code to!

Additionally, closer to the event we will send out another form asking for maintenance information— quick ways for our staff to troubleshoot / reboot your game without needing to call you back to the expo halls. This can be a long-winded debugging guide, but ideally it is just steps to restart the game, how to access power, and simple things that can be done by anybody.

Prepping Your Game

You're going to see a lot of play during the event. Stats from previous developers have been as high as 1200 rounds played during the event. Some thoughts:

- MAGFest attendees are unruly, but respectful. You should prepare for the hardware on your game failing from heavy use. If you can break your game into smaller components that can be swapped out quickly, you should do so. If there are any unique electrical components, e.g. potentiometers, buttons, joysticks, **bring spares**
- You should add stat tracking to your game! It can be as simple as writing out some data to a text file after a game is complete, but could be as complex as tracking statistics for which player/character won each game, how long each game took, etc
- The Indie Arcade is largely left unattended, and event attendees will be walking up to your game blind. Think about how someone who has never seen your game will approach it for the first time. Can you add instruction screens / signage to explain how it works?
- People may get bored and walk away from your game before finishing. Consider adding a timeout if no controls are touched for a certain amount of time and sending it back to a start screen.
- Before the event, leave your game running on your computer at home for 24 hours or more and make sure it doesn't crash for no reason (Definitely not speaking from experience here)
- Tag all of your gear. Loadout can be chaotic, and a simple painter's tape flag with your game's name can help ensure there are no mix-ups and wandering hardware when people are tearing down
- You shouldn't rely solely on bluetooth/wifi/any other wireless comms. The expo halls can be very weird with wireless signals and we've seen issues with bluetooth transmitting over as short as a 10 foot distance. Have a wired backup, if possible.

What to Bring

- Spare batteries for any controllers/external tools
- Headlamp (the expo hall is dark during the show, this makes repairs much easier)
- Tablecloth (for any tabletop-sized games)
- Anything else you would like to dress up your area!
- A water bottle
- Comfortable shoes - the expo hall floors are hard cement and it *will* take its toll.
- Any specialized tools/equipment you need for your game (we have a toolbox with most of the essentials, but we're not Home Depot)
- A humidifier- Especially if you're staying in the Gaylord. You will not experience drier air outside of the mojave. Your sinuses will thank you in the morning.

Load In

Here is an overview of the load-in system as you start to arrive! Please communicate all arrival/logistical needs in MIVS + IA Discord in the #ia-trucks-and-travel channel. We will remind everyone of this information in that same channel prior to the load-in days.

Timeline:

Day	Lower Loading Dock Open	Expo Hall Ramp Open
Wednesday	9 am - 2 am	2 pm - 12 am
Thursday	8 am -10 pm	10 am - 2 pm

Please note: These are best guess estimates and may change closer to the event. We will announce any changes in the discord when we are on-site

Please send us your ETA in Discord via the #ia-trucks-and-travel channel once you hit the road/update us to any changes - this lets us coordinate to have volunteers prepared to assist you on arrival.

Arrive early enough that all games can be unloaded, set up, and fully operational by Thursday at 2 pm when the Expo Halls open.

If you are set to arrive outside of these hours, please contact an IA DH in Discord ASAP and we'll help work out a solution for you.

Where to go to unload:

Lower Loading Dock (truck bays) - for full-size box trucks, 48"-55" height bed

Lower Loading Dock (expo hall ramp) - for smaller trucks with lift gates, other cargo and passenger vehicles

Hotel Parking - for games small enough to be easily carried or transported by hand truck from your vehicle, through a parking lot and the hotel to the expo halls

Arrival steps:

Note: The line to load-in via the loading docks is shared between Indie Arcade, MIVS, and the Marketplace. The waiting line can be over one hour during peak hours. If your game is relatively low-profile and can be carried in by hand from the hotel side, it is recommended to do so.

If you need Loading Dock access (truck bays):

1. On departure, post your arrival ETA in #ia-trucks-and-travel in Discord, and please update us when you're ~15 minutes away, or if your ETA changes significantly.
2. Ping @IA DH in #ia-trucks-and-travel on arrival when you reach the Lower Loading Dock truck line - **skip** the main vehicle line for lower loading dock expo hall ramp
***Note:** There are two sets of loading docks, one at the Ballroom level and one at the Expo Hall level. When coming down the road behind the convention center, you want the **second** set of loading docks (see map below)*
3. Follow directions from staff on the loading dock to back into an available bay.
4. Staff will assist you in unloading games into Expo Hall C with appliance hand trucks and/or pallet jacks.
5. Collect a truck tag from the Logistics JOBOX key storage in Expo Hall E, and tag your truck.
6. As soon as your truck has been unloaded, follow staff directions to drive it to the Southpointe parking lot and park the vehicle.
7. If parked in Southpointe, deliver truck keys to the Logistics JOBOX for storage.
8. Find your game location(s) (tape label, ask a staff member to help you) and set up for the show!

If you need Loading Dock access (expo hall ramp):

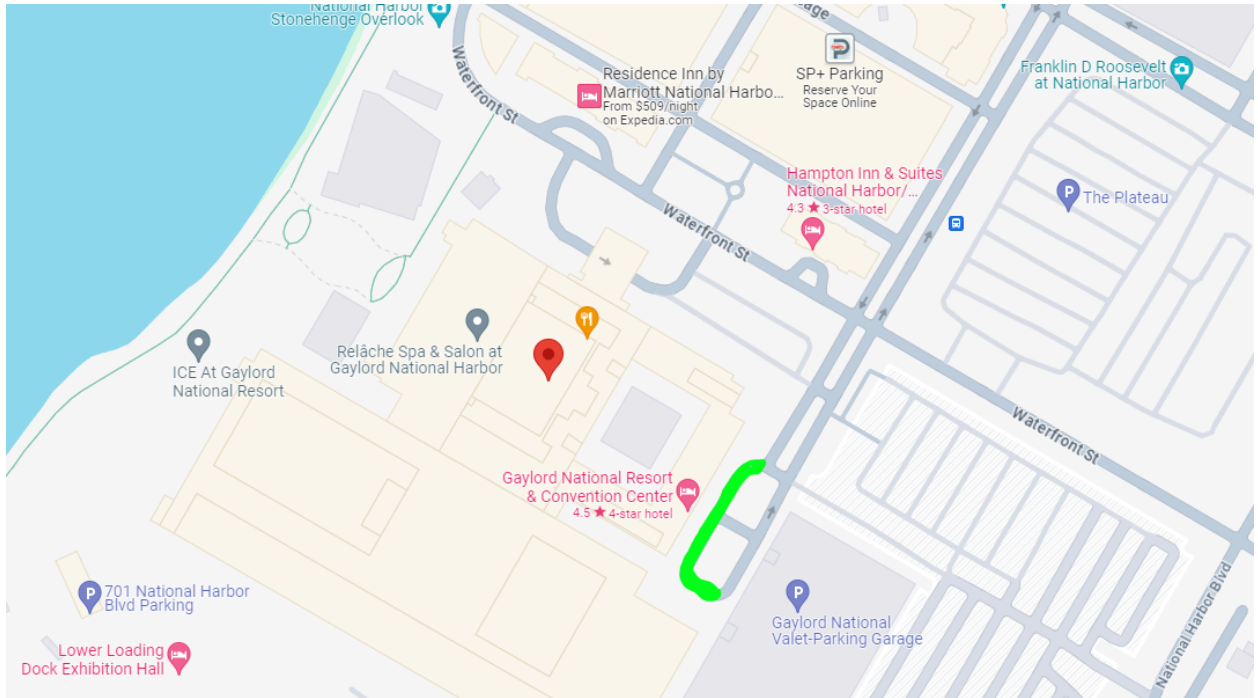
1. Fill out the load-in form ASAP. This will be provided in an e-mail closer to the event.
2. On departure, post your arrival ETA in #ia-trucks-and-travel in Discord, and please update us when you're ~15 minutes away, or if your ETA changes significantly.
3. Ping @IA DH in #ia-trucks-and-travel on arrival when you are in the vehicle line for the Lower Loading Dock Expo Hall ramp.
***Note:** There are two sets of loading docks, one at the Ballroom level and one at the Expo Hall level. When coming down the road behind the convention center, you want the **second** set of loading docks (see map below)*
4. Follow directions from staff to drive up the ramp into the Expo Halls, and park in an available space inside.

- Staff will assist you in unloading onto pallet jacks to be transported to Expo C.
- As soon as your vehicle has been unloaded, follow directions to drive it out of the Expo Hall and park in hotel or street parking at your discretion. *Note: if you have a smaller box truck and would like to park in Southpointe, follow steps 5-7 above for larger trucks*
- Find your game location(s) (tape label, ask a staff member to help you) and set up for the show!



If you don't need Loading Dock access (carrying game by hand):

- On departure, post your arrival ETA in #ia-trucks-and-travel in Discord, and please update us when you're ~15 minutes away, or if your ETA changes significantly.
- Ping @IA DH in #ia-trucks-and-travel on arrival, let us know if you need a volunteer to meet you with a hand truck with your location
- Walk your game to Expo Hall C - Atrium (lowest) level of the convention center
- Find your game location (tape label, ask a staff member to help you) and set up for the show!
- The most convenient place to unload this way is at the 'horseshoe' labeled in green here. You will need to double-park and have someone from your team take your game while you park in a real lot. It's a pretty straight shot to a "secret" elevator and down two floors to the expo halls from here



Note: *This path is highly recommended if your game is of a manageable size, it involves much less waiting and you avoid the loading dock traffic jam.*

When you arrive in Expo Hall C, the rough layout will be in place, and your games will be tagged with spike tape on the floor/tables (subject to slight changes as we shuffle things around to Maximize the Good Vibes). We can provide power extensions and help you set up/safely gaff your cables down. You should provide all other equipment to operate your game(s) for the duration of the event.

Badge Pickup

Historically, though not guaranteed, you will be able to pick up your badge starting Wednesday night. There may be a VIP line that includes indie developers, but this is subject to change year-over-year. This is located in the front of Expo E (the far right hall)

Your badge for the event will include an 'H' tag on it, indicating to security that you have expo hall access. This will allow you to skip the entry line into the expo halls by going in via the exit-only doors, if you present your badge to the security personnel at the door.

If you do not receive an H sticker at registration, please let a department head know, and they can update your registration to indicate that you should have one. After which, you can go back to the registration desk to retrieve your sticker.

If you have an issue with security when trying to enter through the exit doors, don't fight it, and just use the regular entrance doors. Alert an Indie Arcade department head that you had an issue and it will be escalated.

Ribbons

As part of being an indie developer, you get a fancy ribbon to stick on your event badge to show everyone how cool you are! Previously this was used for access control but has been replaced with the H sticker noted above. Track down a department head to get one.

During The Event

Setup, Con't

It can be hard to anticipate some of our layout needs before the event, and how certain games will attract crowds and flow together. While unlikely, we may potentially ask you to swap your space in the expo hall with another game, during the event, to minimize crowding. We recognize that this is inconvenient, but we have a duty to attendees and other developers to ensure we are providing a safe environment

Discord

The biggest thing during the event is keeping tabs on the #maintenance-alerts channel in Discord. If staff (or another developer) notices that your game is down, or seems to not be working correctly, you will be pinged here. This will typically only happen after the maintenance instructions you provided have been attempted. In the case that you receive a ping in this channel, please make an effort to return to Expo C and get your game back online at your earliest convenience. We don't expect you to wake up and leave your hotel at 5 in the morning, but we also expect you to not let your game sit offline for the entire event. If a game is offline for a long time, at DH discretion, it will be pulled from the show floor and stored in the operations booth pending maintenance.

Resources

If you have any issues during the event, there will always be at least two Indie Arcade staffers on shift, around the clock, available at our ops booth in the center of the expo floor. If you need to borrow any tools, they have an inventory of our toolbox at the ready. If there's anything that they are not equipped to handle, they can escalate to a department head, one of whom is always on-call.

We've also got water and non-branded sports drinks available in the booth to keep your whistle wet

Storage

We don't have a formalized system as-of-yet, but you are welcome to, with staff approval, stash a **small** amount of gear in the Indie Arcade ops booth. We may have cubbies available, but there will definitely be some space beneath tables. We simply ask that you clearly label anything you put in the booth. Know that the Indie Arcade cannot guarantee the safety of anything stored there, and it is done **at your own risk**.

Events

The Indie Arcade has historically hosted a mixer for our devs and staff to get to know each other Thursday night. There are usually drinks and also nail polish.

There may also be other smaller events for the department happening throughout the weekend. All of these are optional, but keep your eyes on the Discord to stay up to date on what people are doing!

Tournaments

So, you've decided to run a tournament!

Closer to the event, we will publish a list of time available slots for developers to use to host tournaments. These can be hosted at your booth space, or you can move your gear to the Indie Arcade jampod, where we have a PA and projector ready to go.

Sign ups for tournaments are handled by an internal MAGFest system. Attendees scan their badge at a staff booth and choose your game's tournament. Let players know you have a tournament by leaving signage around your game or using word of mouth. Brackets are made using Challonge and can be accessed via laptop or printed out, staff will assist.

Staff will also assist if you choose to relocate your game and provide an HDMI splitter so your game can appear on your cabinet screen as well as projector, only HDMI however, DVI/Display Port/etc you should bring your own. You should consider having your game run in a standard resolution for the projector or inform staff ASAP so we can try to accommodate.

Tournaments are MC'd by the developer or someone of their choosing, please be respectful as you have a microphone on a PA in a large crowd. Tournament time slots are 1 hour but are typically not back to back in case they run long. You choose the size of the tournament so take into consideration how long a match of your game takes and how many players can compete in that time.

Staff will also provide you with M-Points as prizes, first, second, and third in standardized values.

M-points

M-points are a MAGFest-exclusive form of currency and/or collectible trinkets, available in the equivalent of \$1, \$5, \$10, and \$20. These can be used as cash at most event spaces, but they're also fun to hold on to as keepsakes from the event. They're different each year and can be exchanged for the current-year's m-points. M-points two years old are no longer valid currency.

If you run a tournament, we will provide you with a number of M-points to hand out as prizes. This can vary, but is typically \$10 for first place and \$5 for second place winners.

MAGFest

There's a whole MAGFest happening out there! Go to a concert, go play some arcade games, go to a panel, take photos with cosplayers, pay tribute to Danny Devito, ask someone why everyone keeps roaring randomly...

Go have a great time!

After The Event

Load Out

Expo Halls soft close at 2 pm (no new attendees let in) and hard close at 3 pm (lights on, everyone out). You are welcome to start tearing down anytime after 2pm, or wait until 3pm. If for some reason traffic is extremely low in the hall earlier than 2pm, or you have other circumstances going on today, talk to an Indie Arcade Department Head about getting out earlier - depending on your method of getting out, this may be possible. **Do not pack up before 2pm without getting prior approval from a department head.**

Departure Steps:

If you need Loading Dock access (truck bays) Come talk with us - we need to coordinate bay access with Arcades.

If you need Expo E ramp drive in access

1. If you did not fill out the form for load-in already, fill out the drive in form from the pre-event email (If you already did, you do not need to fill this out again.)
2. Fully tear down your game area and pack all equipment so you are prepared to transport it to Expo E (logistics or our staff can provide pallet jacks, etc). Make sure any MAGFest supplies, power strips, etc are left behind or turned into the booth.
3. Logistics opens Expo E to us for drive-ins at 4pm. After packing fully, retrieve your car and get in line, or drive in if after 4. If this time moves earlier, we will notify everyone in Discord.
4. Once your vehicle is parked in E, our staff or logistics will assist you in loading onto pallets / handtrucks and moving it to Expo E
5. Pack your vehicle and leave. Thanks for being a part of the Indie Arcade!

If you don't need Dock or Ramp access (carrying game by hand):

1. Fully tear down your game area and pack all equipment. Make sure any MAGFest supplies, power strips, etc are left behind or turned into the booth.
2. If walking game out via hotel, do so at any time after 2 (or talk to us about earlier!)
Thanks for being a part of the 2024 Indie Arcade!

Note: Please avoid walking games out via the loading docks - there will be heavy truck use and traffic for vendor loadout. If necessary to do so, consider driving in to E and using the steps above. DO NOT block any truck bays with your vehicle, and if any staff member says move your vehicle, move it!

Feedback

Approximately a week after the event, we'll send someone from your team a Google form to collect feedback on your experience. It's pretty short, and we really value every bit of feedback we get. We can't make a better event without knowing where we can improve.

Discord

You will be migrated from the Active Developer role to the Alumni role. You can and should keep hanging out and talking. Alt control is a small community and there's usually fun talk happening throughout the year. Maybe you'll find someone to collab with on a project for next year 🙄

Changelog

2026-09-14 - Small language tweaks

2025-10-28 - Added some language about selling merch, minor language tweaks